Individual-tree QSM reconstruction and above-ground biomass agreement on TreeScanPL10k: a methodological note for TWIG

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Abstract

I applied the Arbor QSM pipeline to 30 TreeScanPL10k plots (1,616 manually labeled trees) (Stereńczak et al., 2026) to test whether QSM-derived tree metrics and AGB are reliable enough for multi-temporal TLS monitoring. Mesh detection and DBH/height failure rates rise with the stand's height IQR, and the mesh pipeline fails catastrophically on DBH in dense mixed plots — with fitted diameters of 600–2000 cm, 10–100× the true diameter — while QSM does not. QSM AGB, computed as total wood volume × wood density, agrees with Chave allometric AGB at R^2 = 0.453 (N = 1,581) and with raw-point voxel AGB at R^2 = 0.615 (N = 1,614), with the expected factor-100 wood-vs-space offset. The height IQR diagnostic identifies which plots will produce usable tree-level metrics (detection, DBH, height) before any TLS processing is performed; per-plot AGB agreement is not predicted by IQR and is instead dominated by QSM fitting noise and allometric prediction error. Of the two representations compared, QSM is the one that does not catastrophically fail on any tree-level metric, including on the high-IQR plots where the mesh pipeline's DBH failure rate reaches 100%.

Introduction

TWIG will convert repeated TLS acquisitions into multi-temporal AGB estimates at Amacayacu and Alto da Figueira. The workflow requires two things that are not currently well-characterized in the TLS literature: (i) a tree segmentation and reconstruction method that does not catastrophically fail on any structural class, and (ii) a pre-processing diagnostic that tells the analyst which plots will produce usable metrics before time is spent on full processing. This note reports the results of a systematic comparison of two representations — a mesh-based pipeline (TopTreeSegR, https://github.com/DijoG/TopTreeSegR) and a QSM pipeline (arbor, https://www.r-lidar.com/arbor) — applied to the 30 TreeScanPL10k plots (Stereńczak et al., 2026). The goal is not to rank the representations, but to characterize their failure modes and to identify the stand-level diagnostic that predicts them. The findings are directly relevant to TWIG's multi-temporal design.

Data and methods

Data

TreeScanPL10k provides 30 manually labeled TLS plots across six Polish forest districts, spanning pine, spruce-pine, mixed, and broadleaf stands. Each plot contains 10–157 individually labeled trees (1,616 total), with reference DBH (Taubin circle fit in the

1.15–1.45 m band) (Taubin, 1991), height (z-range), and crown volume (0.3 m voxel occupancy above 60% of tree height). The plots span a vertical structural heterogeneity range from 1.3 m to 17.5 m in reference-height IQR.

QSM pipeline

Arbor was applied to each plot with default parameters. The pipeline segments the point cloud semantically (ground, wood, foliage) and fits cylinder models to each tree, producing per-tree DBH (from the taper fit), height (from the uppermost cylinder), and total wood volume V (sum of cylinder volumes from base to tip). Crown volume was computed as the sum of cylinder volumes above 60% of tree height, but is not used in the AGB comparison because it measures wood volume rather than occupied space.

Mesh pipeline

TopTreeSegR was applied to the same semantically filtered point clouds, so that both representations were evaluated on identical input. The pipeline constructs an α-complex mesh (α = 0.05 m), computes a Forman gradient of the height function, identifies density-based seed minima, and traces ascending manifolds to partition the canopy into individual trees. DBH is fitted by a circle in the 1.15–1.45 m band, height is the z-range of the assigned points, and crown volume is computed by 0.3 m voxel occupancy (Calders et al., 2015) above 60% of tree height.

AGB calculation

Three AGB estimates were computed per tree: (i) QSM AGB = V × ρ × 1000, where V is the total wood volume in m^3 and ρ is the species-level or forest-type-level wood density in $\mathrm{g/cm}^3$; (ii) raw-point AGB = V_voxel × ρ × 1000, where V_voxel is the occupied volume of all tree points above the whole tree, voxelized at 0.3 m; (iii) allometric AGB = 0.0673 × (ρ × DBH^2 × H)^0.976 (Chave et al., 2014), applied to the reference DBH and height. Wood density was assigned by forest type: 0.45 for Gorlice mixed, 0.45 for Herby pine, 0.42 for Piensk pine, 0.42 for Katrynka and Suprasl spruce-pine, 0.50 for Milicz mixed. All AGB values are reported in tonnes (Mg). Of the 1,616 labeled trees, 1,614 have both a valid QSM wood volume and a valid raw-point voxel volume; of those, 1,581 also have a valid reference DBH and height. The losses are due to trees with no valid cylinder fit in the QSM output and to trees with no measurable reference DBH, and are not expected to bias the comparison.

Failure flags

A tree's metric was flagged as a catastrophic failure when the ratio of predicted to reference value fell outside [0.5, 2.0] for DBH and height, or outside [0.4, 2.5] for crown volume. A tree was flagged as a detection failure when it was present in the reference but absent from the pipeline output. The stand-level predictor was the interquartile range (IQR) of reference tree heights, computed before any TLS processing.

Results

Tree metrics

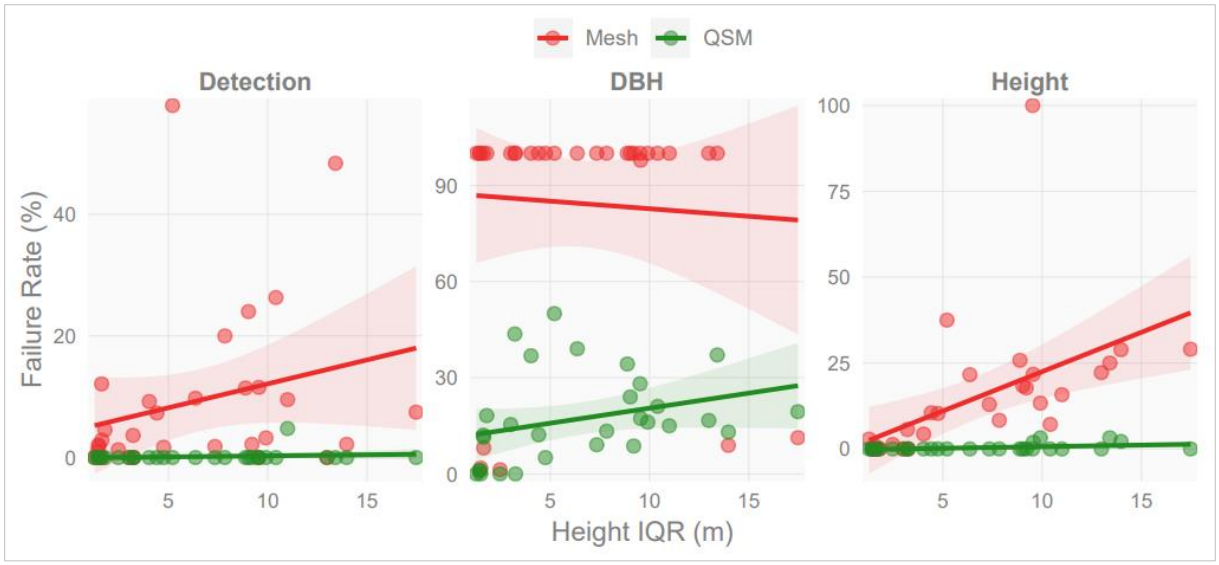


Figure 1. Detection failure, DBH failure, and height failure rates as a function of stand-level height IQR. Points are per-plot failure rates (%; 30 plots), colors are the two representations, lines are linear fits with 95% confidence bands. The mesh pipeline's DBH failure rises from <5% on the lowest-IQR plots to 100% on several mixed plots; on Gorlice_2015_0101703, for example, the circle fit produces fitted DBHs of 600–2000 cm, 10–100× the true diameter. The QSM pipeline's DBH failure remains below 50% across all IQR levels. The same trend appears for detection and height failure, with the mesh failing more and the QSM failing near-zero.

AGB comparison

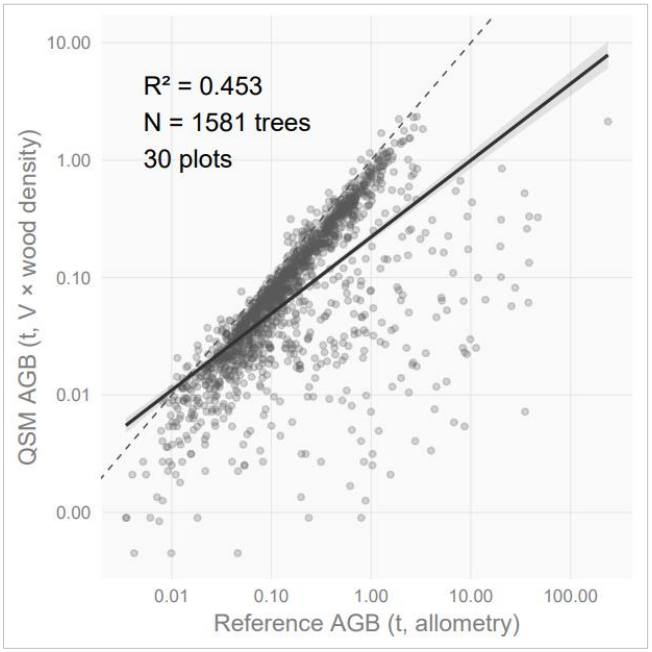


Figure 2. QSM AGB (total wood volume × wood density) against Chave allometric AGB (from reference DBH and height), 1,581 trees across 30 plots. Dashed line is 1:1; solid green line is the log-log regression. The median QSM/allometry ratio is 0.65, reflecting the fact that QSM reconstructs the woody skeleton (excluding fine branches

and bark) while allometry includes total above-ground biomass. The scatter is dominated by two regimes: a tight diagonal ridge of well-reconstructed trees, and a sparse under-estimation tail where QSM fits only the stem.

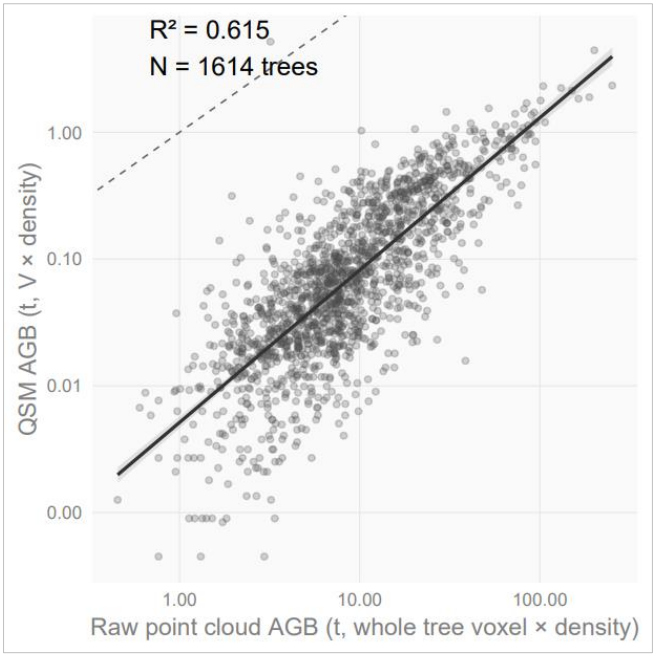


Figure 3. QSM AGB against raw-point AGB (whole-tree voxel occupancy × wood density), 1,614 trees. Both quantities are geometric proxies for tree biomass: QSM measures the woody skeleton, raw-point voxel occupancy measures the occupied crown space (including air between branches). The factor-100 offset between the two is the expected wood-to-space ratio of a tree crown. The R^2 = 0.615 on log axes shows that the QSM preserves the tree-to-tree relative ordering of biomass, which is the quantity that matters for multi-temporal change detection.

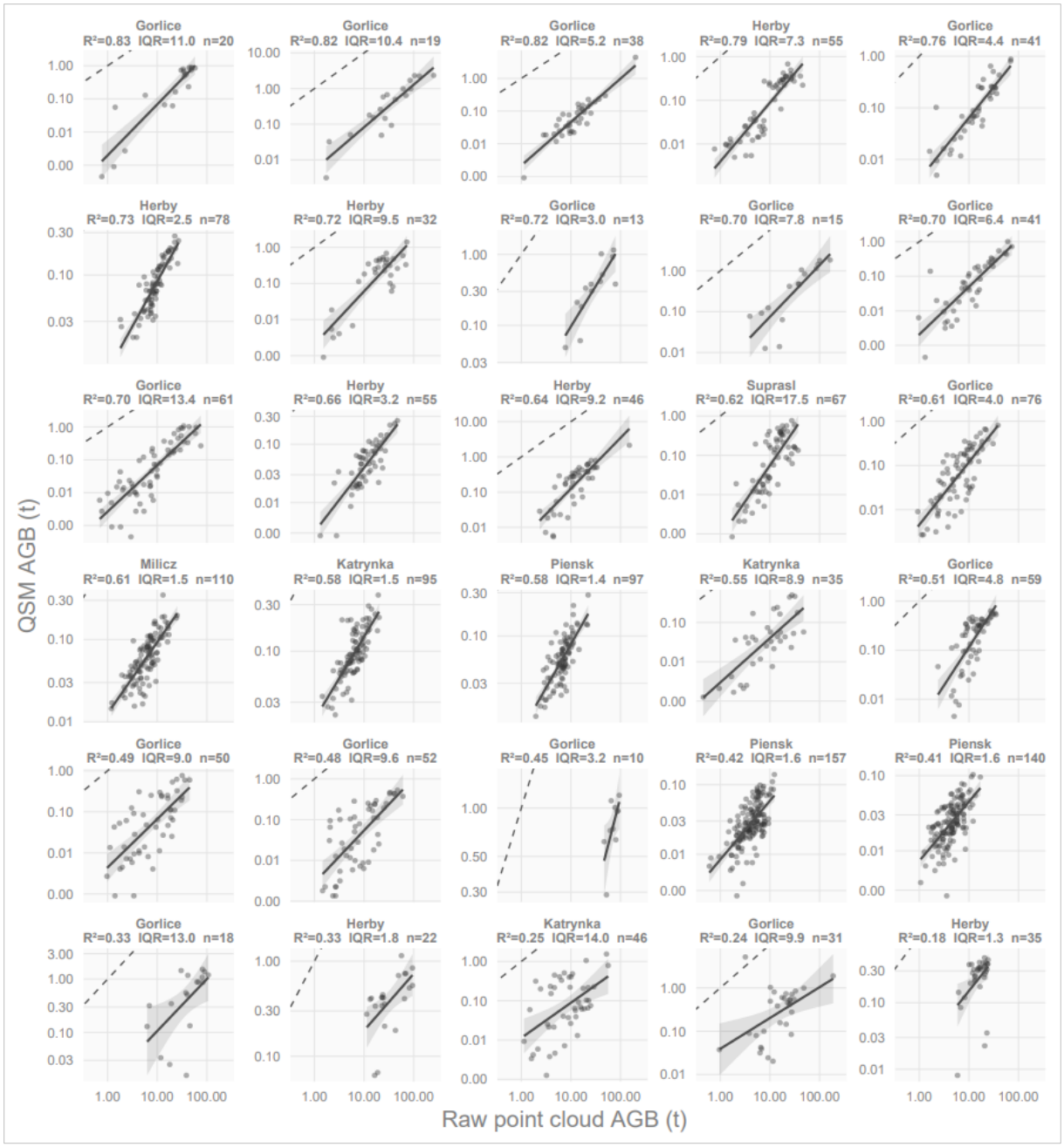


Figure 4. Per-plot QSM AGB vs. raw-point voxel AGB, 30 plots, ordered by per-plot R^2 (descending). Panel titles show the per-plot log-log R^2, the height IQR of the reference trees, and the number of trees. R^2 ranges from 0.18 to 0.83. It is only partially explained by sample size: the highest-R^2 panels include both large plots (Milicz, n = 110, R^2 = 0.61; Katrynka, n = 95, R^2 = 0.58) and small plots (Gorlice, n = 20, R^2 = 0.83), and the lowest-R^2 panel (Herby, n = 35, R^2 = 0.18) is not the smallest. IQR does not track R^2 across panels. The consistent multiplicative offset (~1/100) between QSM AGB and raw-point voxel AGB is the expected wood-vs-space difference (QSM measures cylinder volume; voxel occupancy measures occupied crown space including air between branches), and is independent of the R^2 values, which are computed on log-transformed axes.

Discussion and conclusions

The introduction asked two questions that the TLS literature does not yet answer well: whether a tree reconstruction method exists that does not catastrophically fail on any structural class, and whether a stand-level diagnostic can predict which plots will produce usable metrics before full processing. The results give clear answers to both.

On catastrophic failure. Of the two representations compared, the mesh pipeline fails catastrophically on DBH in dense mixed plots, with fitted diameters of 600–2000 cm (10–100× the true value) because the circle fit in the 1.15–1.45 m band captures the union of adjacent stems (Fig. 1). The QSM pipeline does not have this failure mode: its taper fit starts at the base and grows upward, separating adjacent stems by construction. On the high-IQR plots where mesh DBH failure reaches 100%, QSM DBH failure remains below 50% and height failure below 3%. This is the strongest single finding of the note, and it directly answers the first question: a representation exists that does not catastrophically fail on any structural class in this dataset.

On the stand-level diagnostic. The IQR of reference tree heights, computable from a coarse pre-segmentation crown delineation, predicts which plots will produce usable tree-level metrics. Detection failure, DBH failure, and height failure all rise with IQR for the mesh, and the QSM's near-zero failure is stable across the full range. The diagnostic is not universal: per-plot AGB agreement (Fig. 4) is not predicted by IQR, and is instead bounded by QSM fitting noise and allometric prediction error. This answers the second question with a qualification: the diagnostic applies to tree-level metrics, not to AGB agreement.

Implications for TWIG. For the multi-temporal AGB workflow, three operational conclusions follow. First, QSM should be the reconstruction method for structurally complex plots independently of scanning (MLS or TLS) method, because it is the only representation in the comparison that does not catastrophically fail on any tree-level metric. Second, the height IQR is a pre-processing check: a plot with IQR above ~10 m should be flagged before full processing, and the QSM's per-tree failure rate on that plot can be anticipated from the diagnostic. Third, QSM AGB tracks both allometric and raw-point AGB across the tree-size range (R^2 = 0.453 and 0.615), so it is usable as a relative-change estimator; absolute AGB calibration can be established from allometry or from a small destructive sample, and the residual variance is an open question that TWIG's multi-temporal design is positioned to resolve.

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